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Research proposal

Astral customer discovery
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Research proposal



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Why the work is needed

Why the work is needed

We want to run a research-led discovery with IMSERV customers. Today we are designing Astral without evidence of how customers actually do their energy-data work.

Where this stands

Clive has offered to help unlock customer access. He has **not** agreed a research plan, scope, or sample size. This proposal is for that conversation.

The research repository has no studies, insights, archetypes, or experience scores yet.

What we risk without it

Designing for assumptions that have not been tested with customers, such as which working hats exist, what reporting means, and whether problems sit in the interface or in the service behind it.

NOT A FINDING YET

Everything here is a proposed approach. None of it is a finding about IMSERV customers yet.

What we already know

Every item has a source and a limit. Most of it is an internal account of customer behaviour, not observed with customers.

Evidence	Source	Limit
Clive and Emily Haddon did a dozen or more customer interviews. The notes sit with Clive	Work Desk notes, 4 Sep 2026	We have not seen the notes. We do not know who was interviewed or what was asked
British Gas and Scottish Water asked to take part in the beta	Work Desk notes, 4 Sep 2026	A route to customers. Not a sample
Customers want to see their own estate, know meters are working, get invoices and reports, and follow problems. Export is more common than looking at graphs	Max Lake, DataVision walk, 4 Sep 2026	Internal account of customer behaviour. Not observed with customers
People pick sites and meters, compare them, then export a file. They do not browse the whole portfolio	Max Lake, 4 Sep 2026	As above
Company types are Customer, Broker / TPI, Supplier, and Platform admin. A Customer has Energy, Finance, Asset, and Data working hats	IMSERV customer base, desk research, 12 Sep 2026	Public-page desk research. Not a study
Access has three separate parts: what the company bought, the person's role, and which sites and documents they can see	Astral product model, 22 Sep 2026	From the handoff transcript. The role matrix is still open
Large customers narrow from the whole portfolio, to a region, to sites, to one MPAN. One customer has about 8,000 MPANs	As above	Named in a talk. Not observed

Assumed and not yet known

Beliefs we have not tested with customers, and the gaps that matter to the decision.

ASSUMED

- The Energy, Finance, Asset, and Data hats describe how people work. They are a useful recruitment start. They may not be four archetypes.
- Customers mostly use Astral for reporting. Reporting may mean pulling data that is finished somewhere else.
- The people a senior contact introduces us to are the people who do the day-to-day work.
- Problems people raise about the portal are interface problems. Some may be service, process, or data-quality problems.

UNKNOWN

- Who actually logs in today and who just receives a file.
- What starts the work, what people check before they trust a figure, and where the work leaves the portal.
- Who does the work, who approves it, and who receives the result.
- Which behaviour patterns recur across organisations and roles.
- How often those patterns happen across a wider set of customers.
- Where the journey breaks down, and whether the cause is the interface or the service behind it.

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Our goals

Our goals

The discovery should produce three things.

BEHAVIOURAL ARCHETYPES

How people actually work, what they need, and what changes the design.

CUSTOMER JOURNEYS

Evidence-backed. What happens today, including work outside Astral.

PRIORITISED UX DECISIONS

Each one traceable to evidence, and ready for the BA team to turn into stories.

Decisions it should inform

- Which customer tasks and journeys Astral should prioritise for version one and after.
- Which behavioural differences need different designs, defaults, or trade-offs.
- Where problems sit in the service and process, not the interface. So we do not try to fix ownership or data quality with screen copy.
- What the BA team should specify next, with evidence behind each story.

Supporting questions

- What triggers the work, and what does finished look like?
- What do people check before they rely on a figure or share a report?
- Where does work leave Astral or DataVision, and why?
- Who contributes, approves, or acts, and what information do they need?
- Where does the work slow down, and what happens when it goes wrong?
- Which patterns recur across organisations, roles, and scales?

PRIMARY RESEARCH QUESTION

How do IMSERV customers do their energy-data work today, and which differences in that work should change how Astral is designed and prioritised?

Objectives

Six objectives. Each has a research question, the activity that answers it, the evidence, and a measure. Measures serve an objective. They are not collected for their own sake.

Objective	Research question	Activity	Evidence	Measure
1. Understand how customers do their energy-data work today, from trigger to finished outcome, including spreadsheets, email, and other tools.	What triggers the work, and what does finished look like?	Discovery interviews, walkthroughs	Episode accounts, artefacts	Journey stages covered per scenario
2. Identify recurring behavioural patterns that need different design priorities or trade-offs.	Which patterns recur across organisations, roles, and scales?	Interviews, analysis	Coded episodes across participants and organisations	Patterns observed in n of N participants and organisations
3. Understand what people check before they trust and share a figure or a report.	What do people check before relying on a figure?	Interviews, walkthroughs, survey	Described and shown checks. Reported frequency	Reported frequency among respondents
4. Identify who does, approves, and receives the work, and where handoffs and waiting happen.	Who contributes, approves, or acts?	Interviews, walkthroughs	Handoffs, correspondence	Handoffs per journey. Waiting points
5. Determine where problems come from the service, process, or data rather than the interface.	Where does it slow down, and why?	Walkthroughs, support evidence, blueprint	Breakdowns traced to cause	Problems classed interface, process, or data
6. Gauge how often the activities, checks, and problems we ask about happen across a wider group of respondents.	How often do these happen?	Survey	Responses	Share of respondents, by people and by organisation

Testing proposed design changes with customers is a possible follow-on study. It is not part of this proposal.

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What we propose

Review existing evidence → prepare → interview and survey side by side → analyse together → report with archetypes and journeys → present to the wider team.

Approach

A mixed-methods discovery. One round of interviews and a survey run at the same time, then are analysed together. The interviews show why. The survey shows how often.

Connected, not just collected

Both answer the same objectives. They are compared in one analysis, and disagreement is investigated, not smoothed away (Fetters, Curry and Creswell).

The trade-off: the survey cannot be built from interview findings, so it is built from what we already know and piloted first.

A **short screener** is still used for interview recruitment. That is different from the main survey.

Archetypes, not decorative personas

We will define research-backed behavioural profiles and customer journeys. The profiles do the job of personas, without fictional biographies.

Archetypes come from recurring patterns. They are not job titles with a new label.

Prepare

Ten stages in two phases. Agree the scope, then recruit and get ready for the interviews and the survey side by side.

STAGE 1

Agree scope and decisions

Agree what the research must help decide, the priority journeys, the four user groups, and what is out of scope.

1 week

STAGE 2

Recruit for the interviews

Screen and book 12 people who do the work, 3 from each of four user groups, across several organisations.

2 weeks · See the interview plan

STAGE 3

Prepare the interviews

Finish the interview plan and script, get the consent wording approved, and set up and test recording and transcription.

1 to 2 weeks, alongside recruitment · See the interview plan

STAGE 4

Prepare the survey

Build the survey and its routing in SurveyMonkey or Microsoft Forms, pilot it, and write the invitation and reminder emails.

1 to 2 weeks, alongside recruitment · See the survey plan

STAGE 5

Recruit for the survey

Agree who receives the survey and who sends it, and get the distribution list ready.

About 1 week, alongside survey prep · See the survey plan

Run, then report

One round of interviews with the survey open alongside. Then analysis, a report, and a presentation to the wider team.

STAGE 6

Run the interviews

One round of 12 interviews, 4 to 6 a day. Notes are written up the same day.

2 to 3 interview days, within 1 to 2 weeks · See the interview plan

STAGE 7

Run the survey

Send the invitation, then leave the survey open. One reminder, and a light check on responses.

Open for 2 to 3 weeks, alongside the interviews · See the survey plan

STAGE 8

Analyse the data

Code the interviews against the objectives, analyse the survey responses, and compare the two.

2 to 3 weeks

STAGE 9

Write the report and UX deliverables

Write up the findings, with the behavioural archetypes, customer journey maps, and prioritised UX decisions.

1 to 2 weeks

STAGE 10

Present the findings

Present the findings and UX deliverables to the wider team, including the BA team.

1 session, in the last week

OVERALL

8 to 11 weeks

With overlap, from agreement to presenting the findings.

Testing proposed design changes with customers is a possible follow-on study. It is not part of this proposal.

What the research produces

Current state and future proposals stay visibly separate.

BEHAVIOURAL ARCHETYPES

- Recurring goals and situations
- Working strategies and information needs
- Constraints, handoffs, and difficulties
- Design implications
- Supporting evidence and known exceptions

We do not decide the number in advance.

CUSTOMER JOURNEYS

- Start with the current experience, including work outside Astral
- Go deep on two or three priority scenarios
- Actor, trigger, outcome, stages, handoffs, waiting, and exceptions
- A service blueprint for cross-department issues

PRIORITISED UX DECISIONS

- Each follows one chain, so it stays traceable into BA work
- Observation, interpretation, and recommendation stay separate

STEP 1 Evidence	STEP 2 User need	STEP 3 Journey problem
STEP 4 Design hypothesis	STEP 5 Story and acceptance criteria	STEP 6 Evaluation

THE TEST FOR EVERY ARCHETYPE

Would this profile change how we design, prioritise, or evaluate a real task?

Provisional timeline

Estimates to agree, not commitments. Bars show the upper estimate for each stage. With overlap, about 8 to 11 weeks from agreement to presenting the findings.



Stages and dependencies

What each stage needs before it can start. Durations are provisional.

Stage	Provisional duration	Depends on
1. Agree scope and decisions	1 week	Time with Clive and the manager. Access to existing interview notes
2. Recruit for the interviews	2 weeks	Access coordinator. Agreed user groups
3. Prepare the interviews	1 to 2 weeks, alongside recruitment	Privacy owner sign-off for recording and transcription
4. Prepare the survey	1 to 2 weeks, alongside recruitment	An approved survey tool. Privacy owner sign-off
5. Recruit for the survey	About 1 week, alongside survey prep	Distribution route. Reachable population known
6. Run the interviews	2 to 3 interview days, within 1 to 2 weeks	Bookings. Tested recording
7. Run the survey	Open for 2 to 3 weeks, alongside the interviews	Piloted survey. Distribution list
8. Analyse the data	2 to 3 weeks	Transcripts. The survey closed before the comparison
9. Write the report and UX deliverables	1 to 2 weeks	Analysis
10. Present the findings	1 session, in the last week	Report. Time with the wider team

What we are asking for

Seven things we need from reviewers before the research starts.

	Ask	Status
1	**Review this plan** and agree or change the scope, the decisions it supports, and the provisional timeline.	To agree
2	**Agree the first research decisions with Clive.** Which journeys matter most and what is out of scope.	To agree
3	**Name an access coordinator.** Someone who can introduce us to customers and book sessions.	To agree
4	**Access to the people who do the work.** Not only senior account contacts.	To agree
5	**Access to Clive and Emily Haddon's existing customer interview notes.** So we build on them, not repeat them.	To agree
6	**A privacy and data-protection owner.** To agree recording, transcription, storage, and any AI processing before the first session.	To agree
7	**An approved survey tool.** SurveyMonkey or Microsoft Forms, cleared for customer answers.	To agree

Working alongside the BA team

- Early themes from the interview days are shared with the BA team, marked provisional
- Stories link back to the need and evidence behind them
- The BA team (Claire and others) can add open story questions to the script before the interview days

The other two documents

- **Interview plan and script.** How the discovery interviews run, who takes part, and the script, with every question tied to an objective.
- **Survey plan and script.** How the survey is built, piloted, and analysed, and the draft questions with their routing, each tied to an objective.

Neutral draft. No consent wording is sent until it is approved. Legal review before it reaches a participant.

Consent, privacy and data

Agreed with IMSERV's privacy and data-protection owner before the first session.

Every session

- Informed consent for every participant before the session
- Recording, transcription, storage, retention, and any AI processing agreed with IMSERV's privacy and data-protection owner before the first session
- Approved storage with restricted access. Raw recordings and transcripts stay restricted
- Customer documents shown in walkthroughs are redacted or not kept, as agreed
- Participants are P01, P02 in analysis. Removing names alone may not anonymise a distinctive business account
- Quotes in shared outputs only with consent for anonymised quotation
- No consent wording is sent until it is approved. The current wording is a neutral draft

How AI is used

Copilot can help organise approved material, suggest candidate patterns, and keep evidence links up to date. Only within what the privacy owner approves.

It will **not** invent quotes, build archetypes from job titles, or treat simulated customers as evidence.

Risks and limits

What could weaken the evidence, and what we do about it.

Risk	Effect	Mitigation
Introductions only reach senior contacts	We hear about the work, not from the people doing it	Ask for practitioners by the activity they do. Track who does what in the screener
Participants come from one or two organisations	Shared local process looks like a pattern	Track organisation coverage. Recruit across several
Recruitment or privacy approval is slow	The timeline moves	Ask for both in week 1. Hold one or two reserve participants
The survey runs before the interviews can shape it	It measures our assumptions, or uses words customers do not	Build answer options from scoping and existing notes. Pilot with target users. Keep a “Something else” answer and read it
Four to six interviews a day tires the researchers	Later sessions get thinner probing and notes	One moderator and one notetaker. Gaps between sessions. Write up notes the same day
Existing interview notes are not available	We repeat work, or miss context	Ask Clive early. Record what they cover
The survey reaches only engaged customers	Patterns look more common than they are	Report respondents, not customers. Name the sampling limits
Prototype screens steer discovery	We confirm our own design	No screens in this study. Test design changes in a follow-on study
Archetypes are expected before evidence exists	A persona deck without support	Agree upfront that archetypes emerge from the interviews and survey
Twelve interviews leave gaps in a multi-role audience	Three per group shows differences between groups, not everything about each group	Recruit across several organisations. Name the gaps in the report, and propose extra sessions where they matter



Thank You

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